



Layla: All about the analyze stage

Hi. My name is Layla, and I'm an analytical lead at Google. An analytical lead is someone who helps advertisers understand the value of their advertising dollars. We also help them understand if they were to spend another dollar on ads, where should they spend that dollar, and what could they expect to get from it. The skill set involved in this kind of role has all to do with being able to look at a dataset and make sense of it, and then tell a story to people who maybe don't have that same experience level with data. What's going on in the data? What's driving growth for your client or your company?

What could they do more of or less of to drive more of what they want to happen?

The analyze stage is like preparing a fabulous meal. You have done all the cleaning and the preparing and the cooking, and you're finally able to take a bite and to see if what you're originally hoping to happen or what you were expecting, to see if that is really the case. Is it delicious? Is it exactly like you expected? Or is the consistency a little off and you need to add a little bit more salt? The analysis stage begins once you've prepped and cleaned your data.

You don't want to have those blank fields that will throw you off or duplicate entries that will enlarge your dataset beyond what's actually true. The analyze stage is where you become the expert about your dataset. Here, you're going to understand all of the different fields. You're going to understand their averages, potentially the median of the data. You're going to understand how different rows in your data differ

from each other. And it's where you're going to gain the confidence to be able to explain your findings to an audience that maybe does not have the same level of expertise with data that you have. When I analyze data, I often like to use SQL and spreadsheets.

You can use these tools to, for example, sort your data and understand which entries are larger than others. Or to understand how many times something happens by selecting the distinct entries. Here, you can also filter out data that you are specifically interested in analyzing, or in a spreadsheet, use conditional formatting to show which entries show a more positive outcome and which ones are maybe more negative. Using SQL and spreadsheets to help you through the analyze phase are absolutely crucial. With these tools, you can format your dataset in a way that is digestible and then begin to tell a story with the data. My favorite part of working in a spreadsheet is when you finally have that data that you want cleaned up and exported from your SQL query. Then you get to turn it into a pivot table and chart out exactly the cut of data that you were interested in looking at in the first place and explore the trends that are happening there.

When you get to do that, you basically unlock a whole world of information and you get to pick what story that you actually want to tell with your data without just saying, "This is the largest number; that's the smallest number." Here, you have to show what is happening over time potentially or what you should expect to see in the future.